until you are twenty-seven years old and buried in debt to take control of your money. If you are reading this while you are young, you have the ultimate financial advantage: time. Because you are young, you will not need to completely overhaul your life. You can start taking small, manageable steps today that will help you avoid the pitfalls I, and many others, have experienced.

In closing, because my students love lists, I will leave you with 10 financial tips to live by:

1. **Avoid debt to the best of your ability.** If you have the cash to pay for something in full, do it. Because of the high interest rates, you should be especially afraid of credit card debt.
2. **Don't be fooled by low monthly payments.** Low monthly payments just mean a higher overall price in the long run.
3. **Don't spend too much money on college.** There are a lot of good schools out there. You don't need to bury yourself in debt for a degree that may not help you pay the debt off.
4. **Understand your taxes.** Be sure you know how much you should be paying in taxes, and how much you are actually paying. You don't want to find out that you owe $7,000 in taxes in April, especially if you have not been budgeting for the expense.
5. **Buy a used, reliable car (in cash, if possible).** Don't spend too much money on a new car that is going to depreciate the second you drive it off the lot.
6. **Make a budget.** Don't just estimate how much money you are spending and where you are spending it. You should track every single dollar you earn and spend.